

1 hectare. Micro farmers account to around 78% of the total cultivators, while the area cultivated by these micro farmers is just 36%. Small farmers cultivating 1-2 hectares of land cover 14%, while the land cultivated by them is 26%.

Cultivators of schedule caste farmers are only one percent in Tamil Nadu. 96% of this one percent are small, micro farmers.

The total land area under agriculture is shrinking fast not only in Tamil Nadu, but also throughout India. The number of marginal farmers has increased in India. In contrast, the number of marginal farmers is decreasing in Tamil Nadu. This shows that the farmers are doing other occupations.

4.2 Types of land usage

The total geographical area of Tamil Nadu is One Crore 30 lakhs and 33 thousand hectares. Out of this only one third of land is used for agriculture (45,44,000 hectare). 17% of the land is used for non agricultural use. Nearly the same size (2125 thousand hectares) of land are forests. About 4% of the total land is unusable. One tenth of the land is barren. Other fallow lands are 13 percent. So nearly one-fourth of the land is barren and we have to be concerned of the increasing size of the barren land. Grazing land and cash crops occupy slightly more than 5% of the total land area.

The size of the total cropping land in Tamil Nadu is 4,544 thousand hectare and this keeps on changing every year. Sufficient rains at the proper period will increase this extent of land. Failure or shortage in rainfall leads to the reduction of land usage for cultivation. A small part of this area gives a chance to crop more than once in a year. The extent of this area also changes every year. This land extent was 9 lakh hectare in next year but was reduced to 6 lakh hectare, due to lack of rainfall. This area will be more or less stable only when there is a stable and reliable water source.

In 2012-13, out of the total cultivated land, nearly 72 percent is used for food crops and the remaining for non-food crops.

4.3 Water Resource for Agriculture

There are no perennial rivers in Tamil Nadu. Tamil Nadu receives the required water from the Northeast and Southwest monsoons. When the South West monsoon rains are high in the catchment areas of the Cauvery River in Karnataka dams get filled and in turn the Cauvery river in Tamil Nadu gets water.

The area under irrigation is about 57 percent of the total area under cultivation.

Northeast monsoon (Oct-Dec) is a major source of water for Tamil Nadu. The Northeast monsoon rains are stored in reservoirs, lakes, pond and wells for cultivation. Conventional water bodies like lakes, ponds and canals provide water for agriculture in Tamil Nadu. 2,239 canals run through Tamil Nadu covering a length of 9,750 km. There are 7,985 small lakes, 33,142 large lakes, 15 lakh open wells and there are 3,54,000 borewells in the state where agriculture is carried out with the help of these water resources.

The area of land that is irrigated using water from lakes is very low. Nearly 3.68 lakh hectares of land obtain water from lakes. The canals provide water to 6.68 lakh hectares. Borewells irrigate 4.93 lakh hectares and open wells provide water to 11.91 lakh hectares of land.

Agriculture in Tamil Nadu is dependent mostly on groundwater. Use of ground water for agriculture creates many hardships too. There would be no sufferings if the amount

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